# Topic 12 — Sculpture

**Covers syllabus (click to expand)**

Indian Sculpture | Gupta (गुप्त) Sculpture | Buddhist Sculpture | Temple Sculpture | Stone Sculpture | Bronze (कांस्य) Sculpture | Gandhara (गांधार) School | Mathura (मथुरा) School | Amaravati (अमरावती) School

**Sources:** NCERT An Introduction to Indian Art (Class 11), Themes I, UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025 **Last verified:** August 2026

## Current Affairs

- The **Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath (सारनाथ)** entered the UNESCO World Heritage (विश्व धरोहर) list on **25 July 2026**. It is India's **45th** property and Uttar Pradesh (उत्तर प्रदेश)'s **fourth**. The serial site joins **Chaukhandi Stupa (स्तूप)** with the archaeological remains.
- The **National Emblem** is taken from the Sarnath Lion (सिंह) Capital, adopted (अंगीकृत) in **1950**.

## 12.1 Indian Sculpture

Indian sculpture uses stone, bronze, and terracotta. Religion and the court pay for it. Learn each school with its period and region.

- Indian sculpture begins in the Indus Valley (सिंधु घाटी) with terracotta figurines.
- Metallurgical mastery in the Harappan (हड़प्पा) civilization is epitomized by the iconic lost-wax bronze figurine of the **Dancing Girl** discovered at Mohenjo-daro (मोहनजोदड़ो).
- Mauryan stone is polished **Chunar sandstone**. Pillars and Yaksha–Yakshi images take that mirror finish.
- After the Mauryas, Shunga and Satavahana (सातवाहन) art tells stories on stupa railings. Named sites are **Bharhut** and **Sanchi**.
- The first mature **human Buddha** appears in the **Kushan** age.
- Two Kushan centres matter. **Gandhara is in the northwest.** Mathura** is in UP.
- **Gupta** (गुप्त) sculpture is the classical ideal. Later Indian and Southeast Asian icons copy this calm type.
- Medieval work shifts onto temple walls. South India adds **bronze** processional images.
- A murti is made for worship. Stupa panels teach Jataka stories. Courts also used sculpture as display.
- UP stone homes are **Mathura**, **Sarnath** and **Chunar**.
- UP terracotta homes are **Ahichhatra** and **Kaushambi**.
- Sculpture is not Buddhist-only. Mathura also cut **Jain Tirthankaras (तीर्थंकर)**.

- Hindu temple deities become standard from the **Gupta** age onward.
- **Yaksha** images are older than the Buddha image.

> **Logic:** Never swap **Gandhara (NW)** with **Mathura (UP)** or **Amaravati (Andhra)**.

---

## 12.2 Gupta Sculpture

Gupta sculpture of the fourth to sixth centuries is classical spiritual idealism. **Sarnath** is the peak of Buddhist sculpture.

- Gupta faces look calm. Eyes are half-closed. The body is balanced, not the heavy Kushan type.
- The robe is a **transparent sanghati**. Cloth clings, but the body still shows. That is the Gupta hallmark.
- A halo and a lotus seat become normal.
- The quintessential **Sarnath Buddha** is seated in the **dharmachakra pravartana mudra**, commemorating the Buddha's First Sermon (धर्मचक्रप्रवर्तन) in the Deer Park.
- The stone is pale sandstone, not Mathura's red spotted type.
- Sarnath already holds the Mauryan **Lion Capital**. The Gupta Buddha stands on the same campus, centuries later.
- Mathura workshops still work in Gupta times. The "ideal Buddha" is still the Sarnath type.
- **Udayagiri** near Vidisha (विदिशा) in Madhya Pradesh has the **Varaha** relief of Chandragupta (चंद्रगुप्त) II (चंद्रगुप्त द्वितीय). Do not confuse it with Odisha's Udayagiri–Khandagiri (खंडगिरि) caves.
- **Deogarh Dashavatara (दशावतार)** carries Vishnu panels on an early structural (संरचनात्मक) temple.
- Terracotta continues at **Ahichhatra** and **Kaushambi** in UP.

> **Logic:** Sarnath Buddha = Gupta + dharmachakra**. Kushan Mathura is heavier.

---

## 12.3 Buddhist Sculpture

Buddhist sculpture moves from stupa relief to the human Buddha. The mudra tells the scene.

- Early Buddhist art is **aniconic**. The Buddha is shown as a wheel, footprints, an empty throne, the Bodhi tree, or a stupa.
- **Bharhut** is **Shunga**. Panels are labelled Jatakas. Yakshi brackets appear. It is not Mauryan.
- **Sanchi** toranas (तोरण) carry narrative scenes and Yakshis. Early railings still avoid a human Buddha.
- The human Buddha becomes normal in the **Kushan** age at **Gandhara and** Mathura**.
- **Amaravati** and **Nagarjunakonda** (नागार्जुनकोंडा) (Ikshvaku (इक्ष्वाकु) belt) develop Andhra limestone narrative relief around the stupa.
- **Dharmachakra mudra** (धर्मचक्र मुद्रा) turns the wheel. It marks the Sarnath sermon.
- **Bhumisparsha mudra** is earth-witness. It marks enlightenment.
- **Abhaya mudra** means fearlessness.

- **Dhyana mudra** means meditation.
- **Varada mudra** means boon-giving.
- Bodhisattvas look princely. They wear jewellery. Gandhara types may have a moustache. They are not the shaved monk Buddha.
- Pala Bihar–Bengal later casts Buddhist bronzes around Nalanda (नालंदा).
- Jain sculpture homes such as Mathura **Kankali Tila**, Dilwara (दिलवाड़ा), and Ellora (एलोरा)'s Jain caves belong to a parallel sacred-art map — do not dump every cave under "Buddhist only."

**Buddhist / Jain art-site matrix (quick)**

| Site | Region | School / age cue | What to mark |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Bharhut** | MP | Shunga relief | Early railing narratives; aniconic |
| **Sanchi** | MP | Mauryan start → later | Toranas; early aniconic, later icons |
| **Amaravati** | Andhra | Satavahana–Ikshvaku | Limestone panels; Aryaka-pillars |
| **Nagarjunakonda** | Andhra | Ikshvaku | Related Andhra relief belt |
| **Ajanta** (अजंता) | Maharashtra | Vakataka (वाकाटक) peak | Painted caves + chaitya (चैत्य) / vihara (विहार) |
| **Ellora Jain caves** | Maharashtra | Later rock-cut | Caves **30–34** Jain — not Buddhist-only |
| **Mathura Kankali Tila** | UP | Kushan–Gupta | Jain image findspot |
| **Dilwara / Ranakpur / Palitana (पालिताना)** | West India | Medieval Jain | Marble temple sculpture |

> **Logic:** Early Sanchi = aniconic. Iconic Buddha = Kushan onward. Amaravati ≠ Bodh Gaya (बोधगया).

## 12.4 Temple Sculpture

On a temple, the wall is the scripture. Learn dynasty and theme together.

- **Khajuraho** is **Chandela** work in Madhya Pradesh.
- The temples are **Nagara** and sandstone. The tag is **mithuna** panels, not Dravida (द्रविड़).
- **Konark** is Eastern Ganga (गंगा) work in Odisha.
- The entire temple is architecturalised as **Surya's colossal solar chariot**, featuring **24 intricately carved stone wheels** drawn by **7 galloping horses**.
- **Mahabalipuram** is Pallava. It is open-air granite.
- The named relief is **Arjuna's Penance**, also called Descent of the Ganga. The Five Rathas stand nearby.

- **Brihadeeswara** (बृहदीश्वर) is a Chola granite vimana (विमान). Ritual (कर्मकाण्ड) bronzes matter more here than a crowded wall programme.
- **Hoysala** temples at Belur (बेलूर) and Halebidu (हलेबीडु) use **soapstone** (chloritic schist). Carving is jewellery-fine. The plan is star-shaped.
- **Ellora Kailasa (कैलास) (cave 16)** is Rashtrakuta (राष्ट्रकूट). The whole temple is cut down from living rock.
- **Elephanta** (एलिफेंटा) holds the **Maheshamurti (महेशमूर्ति) / Trimurti (त्रिमूर्ति)** Shiva. It is not Ellora Kailasa.
- **Gommateshwara (Bahubali)** stands at **Shravanabelagola** in Karnataka. It is a colossal Jain image in **kayotsarga. Mahamastakabhisheka** is held every **12** years.
- **Modhera** (मोढेरा) is a Solanki Surya temple in Gujarat.
- Puri (पुरी) Jagannath (जगन्नाथ) images are **wood**. That is the exception to stone and bronze.
- The garbhagriha (गर्भगृह) holds the main murti. The shikhara (शिखर) or vimana carries dikpalas and other deities.

> **Logic:** Khajuraho = mithuna + Chandela. Konark = chariot wheels. Mahabalipuram = Pallava relief**.

---

## 12.5 Stone Sculpture

**Key Classification:** Stone medium — Geographic provenance — Sculpture school

- **Chunar sandstone** comes from the Mirzapur (मिर्ज़ापुर) belt in **Uttar Pradesh. Mauryan pillars take a** mirror polish** on it. The Lion Capital is this stone.
- **Mathura** icons use red or spotted **sandstone**. The region is **Uttar Pradesh. The age is Kushan into Gupta.
- **Gandhara uses grey** schist**. Drapery looks Greco-Roman.
- **Amaravati** and Nagarjunakonda use white or greenish **limestone**.
- Pallava and Chola mass is **granite**.
- Hoysala carving is **chloritic schist**, also called soapstone.
- Bharhut, Sanchi and Khajuraho use central Indian **sandstone**.
- Ellora's monolith is Deccan (दक्कन) **basalt**.
- Relief tells a story on a slab. Round sculpture is a free-standing murti. Rock-cut work subtracts the hill.
- **Didarganj Yakshi** (दीदारगंज यक्षी) (Chauri-bearer) has Mauryan polish. The find is from Patna (पटना). She is a Yakshi, not a Buddha.
- **Parkham Yaksha** is from the Mathura region. It is a colossal early stone guardian.

> **Logic:** Chunar = Mauryan polish. Red sandstone = Mathura. Schist = Gandhara.

---

## 12.6 Bronze Sculpture

Bronze icons are cast by lost-wax (*cire perdue* (सिर पर्ड्यू)). They are portable ritual metal.

- The **Dancing Girl** is from Mohenjo-daro. She is **bronze**, made by lost-wax. She is not terracotta and not stone.
- Chola **utsava murtis** are processional bronzes. They are taken out of the granite temple.
- The cosmic dance of Shiva as **Nataraja** represents the crowning glory of medieval **Chola** lost-wax bronze casting in Tamil Nadu (तमिलनाडु).
- The upper right hand holds the **damaru**.
- The upper left hand holds **agni** (अग्नि).
- The lower right hand shows **abhaya**.
- The lower left is **gajahasta**, pointing to the raised left foot.
- The right foot crushes **Apasmara**, the dwarf of ignorance.
- The ring of fire is the **prabhamandala**.
- Pala–Sena eastern India casts Buddhist bronzes of Buddha, Tara (तारा) and Avalokiteshvara.
- The Pala–Sena metal school centres on **Bihar–Bengal**, especially the **Nalanda** orbit, with dark polished bronze and serene Mahayana (महायान) icons.
- The **Sultanganj Buddha** is a colossal copper image from Bihar. It is now in the British Museum. It is Pala-age metal, not a Chola Nataraja.
- Do not swap Pala bronzes with Chola **Nataraja** processional icons or with tribal **Dhokra**.
- **Dhokra** is tribal lost-wax bell-metal from the Bastar belt. It is not a Chola temple icon.
- The Indus people also used copper tools. The bronze is still the Dancing Girl.

> **Logic:** Nataraja = Chola lost-wax. Dancing Girl = Harappan bronze. Pala = eastern Buddhist bronze — do not swap.

## 12.7 Gandhara School

**North-west | grey schist | Kushan**

- The face is Greco-Roman. Hair is wavy. Robe folds look like a toga.
- The Buddha can look Apollo-like. Bodhisattvas sometimes have a moustache.
- This is the first large crop of standing and seated Buddhas in the northwest.
- A halo often appears. The look is more “foreign” than Mathura.
- Patronage is **Kushan**, in Kanishka (कनिष्क)’s world. This is not a Gangetic red-sandstone school.
- It is not Amaravati. It is not UP.

> **Logic:** Gandhara = schist + Greco-Roman**. If the option says red sandstone, it is Mathura.

## 12.8 Mathura School

**Mathura, Uttar Pradesh | red sandstone | Kushan into Gupta**

- The Buddha here is indigenous Indian. The body is fleshy. Early Kushan eyes are often open.
- The same workshops cut **Jain Tirthankaras**. Mathura is Buddhist and Jain.
- Older Yaksha–Yakshi types feed this iconic body.
- Gupta-period Mathura images exist. The calm “poster” Buddha is still usually **Sarnath**.
- The stone is not grey schist. It is not Andhra limestone.

> **Logic:** Mathura = red sandstone + Uttar Pradesh. Jain + Buddhist together.

---

## 12.9 Amaravati School

**Krishna (कृष्णा)–Godavari (गोदावरी), Andhra | limestone | Satavahana–Ikshvaku**

- Panels are narrative **stupa** (स्तूप) casing slabs. Scenes are crowded and moving. The human Buddha appears in action.
- A prominent rectangular projection (*ayaka* (अयक) platform) surmounted by five **Aryaka pillars** (*ayaka-stambhas*) at each cardinal direction is the diagnostic hallmark of stupas in the Amaravati region.
- **Nagarjunakonda** and Ghantasala are related Andhra sites. The named Aryaka-pillar answer is still **Amaravati**.
- Bodies are flowing. They are not Gandhara’s toga-Buddha.
- The first identity is not Mathura’s free-standing red-sandstone icon.

> **Logic:** Amaravati = limestone + Aryaka-pillars**. Not Bodh Gaya, not Sanchi.

**PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q80**

In which of the following stupas are the features of a platform with **'Aryaka-Pillars'** found?

A. Nagarjunakonda B. Ghantasala C. Amaravati D. Bodhgaya

**Show answer**

**Ans: C — Amaravati.**

---